

# The flip side



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**T**he web has made it a billion times easier to find specific information (which is mostly correct), and completely changed our lives by allowing us to connect to pretty much anyone with a net connection. However, having the ability to get to anything with a few clicks and clacks of a keyboard is not necessarily a good thing.

The fact is that technology has made us lazy. No, I don't mean just physically, I mean mentally as well.

First with television and now the web, we've been overloaded with information and content. Those of us who spend hours a day online are probably digesting more information per day than people did in a month, as little as a decades or two ago. On the surface it looks like the web is making us all smarter, and is raising IQs. The reality is that we now know a lot less about a great deal more.

So why am cautioning you about the web in an issue that carries our own *Web Awards 2009*? Because part of true understanding stems from looking at everything from all angles – the flip side of popular perception, in a way.

I've been very close to people in the education sector my whole life – both my parents were teachers – and the one common complaint I hear often from experienced educators across the globe is that education has been dumbed down too much. It's very much the same for the knowledge we gain from the web these days. If we want to know something, we do a quick Google search, hit the first few links, read a few paragraphs and think we know everything there is to know about the topic at hand. The discipline and rigour that in the past drove science, technology and other developments, has been eroded by the ease of access to everything – whether it's quickie microwave meals that prevent us from learning how to cook and appreciating good food, or plagiarising online content to do our educational/work projects, and thus preventing us from truly learning and understanding.

The three most popular uses of the web these days are networking, communicating and sharing opinions and content. Sure we have a ton of friends on social networking sites, but we rarely meet any of them, let alone have any meaningful conversations. We're basically still social animals, succumbing to peer pressure, and striving for popularity online, just as in the real world. There are millions of people who have hundreds of "friends" online, who still find themselves sitting alone in front of their screens longing for some 'real' interaction.

We communicate several orders of magnitude more than we used to, but it's mostly forwards and jokes and spam. We're basically making the same mistakes we've always made, but just on a larger scale. If you look at the most watched TV

series these days, and realise the utter manure that's being dished out in the form of "reality shows", you understand my concern for the way the web is headed. Yes there's probably more trash online, and yes there are people who gobble it all up, but I'd hate to see the trash become the majority of content out there. In its defence, there is still some excellent material on TV – the usage of the masses has not changed that – and there are still brilliant TV producers.

Although the Web 2.0 phenomenon has supposedly given all of us a voice of our own, effectively giving us the opportunity to be brilliant producers in our own right, the majority is more likely to parrot (if not plagiarise) a single original source or idea. Understanding comes from challenges, not the ease offered by "information at your fingertips".

No matter how flashy and expensive your car, you still need to be a good driver, and the faster the car, the greater the danger of crashing. We are developing ever more powerful technologies, but is our understanding of these systems keeping pace with developments? As I've said before, when it comes to technology, most problems exist between keyboard and chair (PEBKAC).

All technologies are developed by a select few inspired and intelligent individuals. But these technologies are used by or affect us all. We need the general population to be educated much better in order to use these technologies effectively and skilfully. All technologies can be used to good or ill, and the more widespread the usage of the technology, the greater the need for skill and understanding. One way to achieve this is to understand those that develop the modern world, and the first step is to recognise these individuals and companies and the innovations they've made.

*Digit* is playing its part in this aspect, and is looking to felicitate both companies and individuals who contribute to improving the technology around us. Our *Young Indian Innovator* initiative aims to spread awareness and identify individuals who have made significant contributions to technology from our country. Our yearly *Icons of Trust* initiative rewards brands for listening to the needs of the users, and providing excellent products and service. We've also started a category called *Reader of Trust*, to felicitate those of you who have spread awareness, helped and educated your peers. You will find details inside this issue, so make sure to participate and ensure that all of us put technology to the best use possible.

  
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